

Chapter 170-1

After Feng Xian finished saying those words, Liang Shi also went to Shi'an Hospital to investigate.

But Shi'an Hospital was like an impenetrable fortress—after more than twenty years, nothing could be found.

Even Zhao Xuning couldn't find anything.

Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu everything she knew.

Xu Qingzhu's conjecture was the same as hers.

However, after voicing her conjecture, Xu Qingzhu also fell silent. The two sat together on the sofa at home while an advertisement played on the TV, Zhao Ying's face moving across the screen.

Neither of them was in the mood to watch.

Liang Shi had already passed her initial shock and now felt very calm.

She felt that even if the investigation confirmed it one way or the other, she could remain unperturbed.

But after a while, Xu Qingzhu suddenly turned to ask her, "So, are you afraid?"

"Afraid of what?" Liang Shi asked in return.

"Afraid that you're not worthy of the Shen family," Xu Qingzhu said with certainty.

Liang Shi: "....."

She had to admit, Xu Qingzhu had the ability to hit the nail on the head.

But Liang Shi didn't only have this one emotion.

At first, she had thought this way because the Shen family was too far out of her reach.

Even though she knew Gu Yixue and Zhao Xuning, and was fairly good friends with both of them.

But she didn't feel that this made her any closer to the Shen family.

Later, she became somewhat sensitive about it. She always felt that searching for one's birth parents should be the parents' effort, and her taking such actions might be seen as having ill intentions.

She was unwilling to bear the consequences of a family reunion, nor was she willing to change the status quo, so she simply didn't pursue it.

Why bother?

Using these two words to persuade herself was more effective than any amount of overthinking.

After careful consideration, Liang Shi slowly shook her head. "A little, but that's not all of it."

"I think my current life is already very good," Liang Shi said. "There are really only two possible outcomes, and I've imagined what might happen with either result, but I feel it would overturn my current life, so I'm unwilling."

After thinking it over, Xu Qingzhu also nodded, though she was more of a practical person than Liang Shi.

"Whether it will overturn your life or not, that can only be determined after confirming first," Xu Qingzhu said.

Chapter 170-2

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Confirming something was easy to say but not simple to do.

With the New Year approaching, many things piled up together. Everyone was too busy to manage, so the matter was temporarily set aside.

After the New Year passed, Xu Qingzhu was busy for quite a while.

Liang Shi didn't rest either. Through Chang Hui's negotiations, she auditioned for two dramas and ultimately secured the role of the second female lead in a historical costume drama.

Once the Lantern Festival¹ passed, she began recording the travel variety show *"Let's Go, Right Now."*

This program had started recording after the New Year, and reportedly had already filmed up to the third episode. Liang Shi would appear as a flying guest² in episodes 4, 5, and 6.

At the same time, *"Journey of the Heart"* was scheduled to release on April 11th.

"Let's Go, Right Now" used a 4+3 format—four fixed guests plus three flying guests.

There would be twelve episodes in total, expected to air in early March.

There were some leaked photos of the show online, but very few.

The production team protected it well. From the limited information online, one could only tell that the fixed MCs included a popular young idol, an aloof Best Actor, an experienced host, and one person whose identity hadn't been revealed at all.

The popular young idol was famously bad-tempered, the aloof Best Actor was known for his zen-like personality, and the host had been honed through various major award ceremonies.

One could tell at a glance that sparks would fly when they came together.

Liang Shi also asked Chang Hui what she needed to be aware of.

Chang Hui thought for a moment before telling her, "One of them brought investment into the show. If you can build a good relationship, then do so. If you can't... just don't provoke her."

Perhaps because she knew Liang Shi also had backing, her words weren't too harsh.

As for who would be parachuting in³ alongside her, Liang Shi didn't know either.

Chang Hui didn't tell her, saying that since it was a reality show, what they wanted was the most instinctive reactions. Telling her in advance would ruin the dramatic effect.

The reality shows here were similar to the ones Liang Shi had participated in before, though comparatively, this one was more authentic.

It placed more emphasis on the first two characters⁴ rather than the last one.

Back when Liang Shi used to film reality shows, a single entrance shot might need to be filmed seven or eight times.

And she'd heard of celebrities who had to film twenty or thirty takes.

When reality shows lose their authenticity, they also lose that purity.

The audience knew it was all an act, so naturally the ratings couldn't hold up.

Some netizens even joked that variety show regulars had better acting skills than actual actors.

So this program would start airing after filming two episodes, mainly to leave time for post-production editing and subtitles. After that, it would basically be filmed weekly and aired weekly—not quite real-time, but close to it.

Post-production could adjust the recording style and guest invitations based on audience feedback.

The recording location for this show was in the south, by the sea.

Liang Shi would be away for a week.

Xu Qingzhu had known about this for a while, but when she heard Liang Shi say she'd be leaving for a week, her face still fell. That evening, she even followed her into the kitchen while she was cooking. "Why is it so long?"

Liang Shi chuckled softly. "This variety show is travel-themed, so it takes longer."

Ordinary variety show recordings only took a day or two.

"You might as well just film a drama then," Xu Qingzhu said.

"Compared to variety shows, I also prefer filming dramas," Liang Shi said as she placed the food on the dining table. "But variety shows help artists maintain exposure, so I still need to participate. I've calculated it—by the time this finishes airing, *Journey of the Heart* will be coming out, so... it's good for the movie too."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "Being an actor is really hard work."

Hearing this, Liang Shi smiled softly and picked up some food with her chopsticks for her. "Not as hard as what you do."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"That's true," Xu Qingzhu said. "We do work quite hard, after all, we're supporting so many artists."

Liang Shi was amused by her, but played along. "Yes, yes, yes. So your artist is going out to work hard now."

"Alright then." Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow and patted her shoulder. "Xiao Liang, work hard so I can buy a house soon."

Liang Shi: "?"

"You're still short of houses?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu nodded calmly. "Of course."

"To keep a beauty in a golden house⁵, I'm just missing the golden house," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "....."

"Alright," Liang Shi said. "Then I'll work harder so President Xu can buy a golden house."

"When the time comes, will you walk in yourself, or should I tie you up and drag you in?" Xu Qingzhu asked leisurely, drawing out her words.

Liang Shi: "I'll carry you in."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

Liang Shi curled her finger and lightly tapped her. "If the golden house only hides me, then it loses its meaning."

Xu Qingzhu: "So?"

"I need to bring you in too," Liang Shi said. "That way it'll be properly hidden."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"I'm not going," Xu Qingzhu said. "I need to earn money to support the family."

"What about me then?" Liang Shi said. "Do I just lie in the golden house and never come out?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Sure."

Liang Shi flicked her forehead again. "Stop playing around, let's eat. Always saying such improper things."

Xu Qingzhu shrugged. "What proper things do I have to say to you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Footnotes:

¹ **Lantern Festival (元宵節):** A Chinese festival celebrated on the 15th day of the first lunar month, marking the end of the Chinese New Year celebrations. It typically falls in February or early March.

² **Flying guest (飛行嘉賓):** A term used in Chinese variety shows referring to guest stars who appear for one or a few episodes, as opposed to the regular/fixed cast members.

³ **Parachuting in (空降):** Entertainment industry slang for someone suddenly joining a show or project, often referring to guest appearances.

⁴ **First two characters vs last one:** In Chinese, "真人秀" (zhēnrénxiù) means "reality show." The first two characters "真人" mean "real person/authentic," while the last character "秀" means "show." The author is saying this program emphasizes authenticity over performance.

⁵ **Golden house to hide a beauty (金屋藏嬌):** A famous Chinese idiom originating from Emperor Wu of Han, who as a child said he would build a golden house to keep his cousin Chen Ajiao (whom he later married). It now refers to keeping a beloved woman in luxurious hidden quarters, often with connotations of keeping a mistress.

Chapter 170-3

Before going to sleep, Xu Qingzhu took out the eye mask she had bought a few days ago from the drawer, put it on, and lay in bed waiting for Liang Shi.

When Liang Shi came back after washing up, she saw Xu Qingzhu lying there in a white off-shoulder dress, wearing an eye mask, breathing evenly—it sounded like she was asleep.

Liang Shi lightened her footsteps, carefully walked in, got into bed, and turned off the light.

But the moment the light went off, it turned back on again.

"You're not asleep?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu didn't remove the eye mask. "I was waiting for you."

"I'm back," Liang Shi said. "Go to sleep."

"What time are you leaving tomorrow?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Nine o'clock."

"That should be fine then."

Liang Shi said, "By the time I get there, it'll be evening. I won't be able to reply to your messages while I'm on the plane."

Xu Qingzhu burrowed into her arms. "I know."

No matter how you listened, there was a hint of unhappiness in her voice.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi's hand fell on her back, gently stroking. "Unhappy?"

"We're going to be in a long-distance relationship—how could I possibly be happy?" Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly. "Are you feeling pleased? Finally able to get rid of me."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi bit her lip lightly. "Why are you saying such angry words?"

"Then... coax me." Xu Qingzhu leaned close to her ear, her words barely more than a breath.

Liang Shi smiled softly but held back from laughing out loud. "How should I coax you?"

"Coax me properly," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi kissed her lips. "Is this okay?"

Xu Qingzhu: ".....So perfunctory."

She took off the eye mask. "I'm not pretending to sleep anymore. I'm too annoyed to fall asleep."

Her eyes met Liang Shi's directly, with the eye mask still resting on her nose bridge.

After becoming pregnant, she had become somewhat sensitive to light, so she wore an eye mask to sleep every night.

Liang Shi stared at her intently, then pulled her onto herself in one motion.

Liang Shi's hand rested on her neck. "Then tonight..."

Her voice paused slightly: "I'm yours for the picking."¹

After saying this, her ears were burning so hot they felt like they might fall off.

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu leaned down and kissed her, then whispered close to her ear, "You just want to be lazy."

"What are you talking about?"

Between kisses, Liang Shi complained, "You're pregnant."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow. "You just want to be lazy."

That raised eyebrow looked like a provocation.

Liang Shi was helpless. She flipped over and sat up, her arm still resting on Xu Qingzhu's waist, and pinched her waist while she was at it. "Careful or I'll bite you."

The corners of Xu Qingzhu's eyes were already tinged with red, yet she still provoked, "Bite where?"

The moment her words fell, Liang Shi bit the side of her face.

Xu Qingzhu winced in pain. "Were you born in the Year of the Dog?"²

Liang Shi pushed the eye mask up to cover her eyes, and said matter-of-factly, "You told me to bite you."

Xu Qingzhu: ".....I told you to coax me....."

Before she could finish, her words were swallowed up.

Liang Shi took over her words, and while she was at it, undid the buttons of her pajamas.

"Isn't this coaxing you?" Liang Shi said softly. "My little ancestor."³

Her gentle voice carried a hint of indulgence.

Footnotes:

¹ **"I'm yours for the picking"** (任君采撷): A classical Chinese expression meaning "at your disposal" or "yours to pluck/pick as you wish." It's a poetic way of offering oneself, often with romantic or intimate connotations. The phrase originates from poetry about picking flowers or fruits.

² **"Were you born in the Year of the Dog?"** (你屬狗的啊): A Chinese expression used when someone bites you, referencing the Chinese zodiac. It's a playful complaint meaning "Why are you biting me like a dog?"

³ **"My little ancestor"** (祖宗): A Chinese term of endearment used sarcastically or affectionately when someone is being demanding or difficult to please. It literally means "ancestor" but is used to express "you're so hard to serve" in a doting way.

Chapter 170-4

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The second filming location for *"Let's Go, Right Now"* was a seaside town in Ling City. Because of its rich marine resources and unique town culture, it was known as the "Town of Paradise."

When Liang Shi arrived in Ling City, it was 7 PM in the evening, and the sky was still its usual blue.

In ordinary Haizhou City, the night would have already blanketed the land by now.

Filming had already started from the moment Liang Shi went to the airport, so naturally there was also a filming crew waiting at Ling City's airport. She had already received the task card from the production team.

The first task was to meet up with the other flying guest.

But she didn't even know who the other flying guest was.

She looked at the camera for help: "So... where should I go to find my partner?"

No one told her.

However, there were clues on the task card: female, red, long whip.

Extracting three words from three pictures, Liang Shi tentatively asked, "Yang Shuyan?"

Still, no one told her.

The staff nearby seemed like AI, focused solely on their work.

So Liang Shi waited there. After waiting for a while, she heard a commotion in the airport. She immediately stood up from her suitcase and said with certainty, "My partner is here."

It really was Yang Shuyan.

However, this was a private itinerary.

The reason it caused such a big commotion was because Yang Shuyan had taken off her mask to sneeze and was recognized at the airport. Word spread from one person to ten, then to a hundred, and that's how so many people came to watch.

It saved Liang Shi some trouble.

Seeing that it was Yang Shuyan, Liang Shi felt somewhat relieved—at least there was someone she knew.

She and Yang Shuyan didn't even need to introduce themselves. When Yang Shuyan saw her, she just nodded slightly without being particularly friendly.

Yang Shuyan was naturally a cold person, so Liang Shi didn't think much of it.

After waiting there for a while, they received a phone call from someone else asking where they were, saying a car was coming to pick them up.

After waiting another five minutes, a car finally arrived.

The people who came to pick them up were the Best Actor and the veteran host.

The Best Actor was named Han Qian. He was already in his forties, but his baby face made him look like he was in his twenties. Apart from the crow's feet at the corners of his eyes slightly revealing his age, you couldn't tell at all otherwise. Liang Shi had also watched his movies—his acting was indeed quite good.

The host was called Qiqi, in her thirties, with a very intellectual face. These two had been good friends for many years. The first interview the Best Actor ever did was with Qiqi. Even though both of them were now married, there were still CP fans¹ shipping them online, though most were shipping their friendship.

In the past, even their casual chat variety shows that were relatively unknown could break 100 million views.

Liang Shi went forward to introduce herself to them, then got in the car.

Yang Shuyan had worked with both Han Qian and Qiqi before, so the atmosphere wasn't awkward. After getting in the car, the host also cued Yang Shuyan, asking what she'd been busy with lately and why she wanted to join this show, and so on.

Only Liang Shi was like an invisible person—no works, no fans, and she'd just come directly to be on a variety show. Liang Shi could already imagine that the annotation the production team would put next to her name would be: New generation actress.

Mm, a new generation actress with no works.

She hadn't expected that after doing this for so many years, she'd have to start over again.

Qiqi didn't let Liang Shi feel awkward either. She threw her some conversation topics, asking how she felt about this place and what she wanted to eat tonight. She also complained to them about the production team's tricks. Liang Shi responded politely.

It took an hour to drive from the airport to the recording location.

By the time they arrived at the recording house, it was already dark.

But this place was truly beautiful—a different kind of scenery when the sunset was setting, and another kind of beauty when night fell.

Liang Shi took quite a few photos.

That popular young idol was very good-looking, with a more feminine kind of beauty. According to his profile, he was an Omega, named Bai Yu.

After Liang Shi arrived, she greeted everyone. There was still one person missing.

As soon as Qiqi entered the door, she asked, "Where did Ranran go?"

Bai Yu shrugged. "She seems to have an upset stomach."

"What did she eat?" Qiqi frowned. "Did you cook?"

Bai Yu: ".....It wasn't me... Okay fine, it was me, but I made it for myself. Who knew she would eat it?"

"It was my own fault for being stupid." A sweet female voice came out, carrying a hint of weakness. "I accidentally mixed up my food with Xiao Bai's."

Then that figure slowly walked out, still holding her stomach, her complexion pale.

She had her hair in a high ponytail, with stray hairs at her forehead making her look somewhat haggard. She wore a light gray tracksuit, presenting quite a sunny girl image.

But Liang Shi's expression changed.

"How are you feeling?" Qiqi went forward with concern. "I have stomach medicine. Do you want to take some?"

"What if you give it to her and it makes things worse?" Bai Yu said. "Wouldn't drinking more hot water be enough?"

Qiqi: "....."

"Xiao Bai." Qiqi said helplessly. "Has anyone ever told you that you're really asking to be beaten?"

Bai Yu touched his nose sheepishly. "Am I wrong though?"

Han Qian patted his shoulder. "Someone still has to pour the hot water, right?"

"I'll go." Bai Yu put one hand in his pocket and was about to leave. After taking two steps, he turned back and asked somewhat bashfully, "Sister Shuyan, do you want to come with me?"

Yang Shuyan: "?"

"No need." Yang Shuyan declined politely. "I need to go sort out my things first."

Hearing this, Bai Yu immediately went forward to help her carry her suitcase, but couldn't lift it. An awkward moment ensued.

Yang Shuyan patted his shoulder. "Alright, go play somewhere else."

It was only when Bai Yu came closer that Liang Shi found him familiar. Bai Yu felt the same way, pointing at her for a few seconds before saying, "We've met before, right?"

Liang Shi: ".....I think so."

"A few days ago." Yang Shuyan said helplessly. "At the wedding."

"Ah ah! I remember now!" Bai Yu said. "I know who you are."

Liang Shi: "I also know who you are now."

Because there were cameras present, Bai Yu didn't reveal too much information about Liang Shi, and the two just played a guessing game there.

The guessing game left everyone confused. Even the usually zen Han Qian couldn't help but ask, "You all know each other?"

Liang Shi nodded. "It's thanks to our mutual friend who held a wedding a few days ago."

Bai Yu said, "Don't even mention it. The moment she got married, she disappeared. I can't find her at all."

"She hasn't even gone to work," Liang Shi said. "She's probably on her honeymoon."

"Other people's honeymoons last one month." Bai Yu rolled his eyes. "Hers is almost two months now."

"I think she went back to work today," Liang Shi said. "If you have something, you can contact her tonight, but... it's probably best if you don't have anything."

Bai Yu: "Why?"

Liang Shi: "They... should both be busy with work."

Bai Yu: ".....?"

Liang Shi had her own ulterior motives.

Footnotes:

¹ **CP fans (CP粉)**: Fans who "ship" or support a romantic pairing between two people (whether real or fictional). "CP" comes from "coupling" or "couple." In this context, they're fans who ship Han Qian and Qiqi together, though mostly as a friendship rather than romantically since both are married.

Chapter 170-5

Sally and Lin Luoxi had finished their honeymoon, so naturally they were very busy after returning to the company.

That meant they could help share a lot of Xu Qingzhu's workload.

Because they had mutual friends, the conversation went quite well.

Bai Yu wasn't as bad-tempered as the rumors suggested—he was just a bit childish. At only twenty-one years old, he really was quite young.

Later, Liang Shi heard from Yang Shuyan that Bai Yu was the child of Lin Luoxi's parents' friends. He had lived at Lin Luoxi's house for a while when he was young. Back when they used to play together, he was just a little tagalong.

Because there were people she knew, Liang Shi wasn't so reserved.

The most critical person was Liang Xinran.

She had heard Liang Wanwan mention her before, but she hadn't expected to encounter her on a variety show. Liang Xinran certainly knew where her strengths lay—her acting wasn't good, so she came directly to variety shows to build goodwill with the general public.

As it turned out, her skill at socializing worked even better in variety shows. Everyone quite liked her. Even when the staff chatted about her, they all said this young miss had no airs at all.

The biggest sponsor was a famous brand under Dongheng, so most of the advertisement placements featured Liang Xinran.

During dinner, Qiqi even brought it up: "Liang Shi, Liang Xinran—you two share the same surname."

Liang Xinran smiled gracefully. "Yes, it's quite a coincidence."

Liang Shi felt uncomfortable inside but just responded with a faint smile.

When rooms were assigned that night, Liang Shi was in the same room as Yang Shuyan.

There were cameras in the room too. Yang Shuyan and Liang Shi chatted officially for a bit—enough footage to edit—then covered up the cameras, and only then did it become their private space.

Yang Shuyan got straight to the point and asked, "Do you have a grudge with Liang Xinran?"

"It's not even a grudge," Liang Shi said. "It's probably more like... enmity."

Yang Shuyan: "?"

"It's quite a complicated matter." Liang Shi asked, "What's wrong?"

Yang Shuyan paused for a moment. "It's best not to show it on the program. Also, try to avoid her."

Liang Shi asked back, "Is it because she brought investment into the show?"

"Mm." Yang Shuyan said, "Dongheng is behind her, and the current person at Dongheng has pretty ruthless methods. Although you have Xu Qingzhu, it's still best not to make a scene in public. It wouldn't be good for either you or Xu Qingzhu."

Liang Shi: "....."

After hearing these words, her heart was suddenly filled with mixed emotions.

However, Liang Shi knew Yang Shuyan was looking out for her, so she thanked her and then asked, "Did Sister Ying ask you to look after me?"

She didn't quite believe Yang Shuyan would be so kind-hearted on her own.

Yang Shuyan had already changed into her pajamas and casually lay down on the bed. "Mm, she quite likes you."

Liang Shi teased, "She seems to like you more though?"

Hearing this, Yang Shuyan turned her head to look at her. After a long while, she finally curved her lips into a light smile. "What does she like about me?"

Liang Shi shrugged. "How would I know? You'd have to ask Sister Ying."

After saying this, Liang Shi sent a message to Xu Qingzhu: [Are you asleep?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Waiting for you.]

Liang Shi: [What time did you get home today?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Eight o'clock.]

Liang Shi: [What did you eat?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Roast duck.]

Liang Shi instinctively typed two characters first, wanting to praise her with "great job," but before sending it, she suddenly had doubts. She deleted everything and edited: [With who?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Lu Jiayi, and... her fiancée.]

Liang Shi: [They're really engaged?]

Xu Qingzhu nodded: [Yes.]

Liang Shi video-called her, but Xu Qingzhu's line was busy.

She waited two seconds and was about to call again when Xu Qingzhu had already called her back.

In the video, Xu Qingzhu was leaning against the headboard, wearing a pink pajama set—the one they bought when they went shopping together and "mutually wounded"¹ each other last time.

Because Liang Shi had said Xu Qingzhu didn't have many pink clothes, Xu Qingzhu shot back that she didn't have any either.

So the two of them bought two sets together—matching couple outfits.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Mutually wounded"** (互相傷害): A playful internet slang expression meaning to tease or poke fun at each other, or in shopping contexts, to encourage each other to spend money on things they might not normally buy. Here it refers to them playfully challenging each other to buy pink clothes.

Chapter 170-6

"Who were you calling?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "Teacher Liang is so busy the moment she leaves home?"

"You, of course," Liang Shi said. "But your line was busy."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Unable to find a reason to argue, she dropped it.

Xu Qingzhu enthusiastically gossiped with Liang Shi: "Lu Jiayi's fiancée is so beautiful."

Liang Shi: "?"

"More beautiful than you?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu couldn't hide her smile, nodding frantically. "She has that kind of angular beauty, even more Alpha than Lu Jiayi."

Liang Shi: "?"

This didn't feel good.

"Did you add her?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu: ".....I was too embarrassed to. Next time, maybe."

When Xu Qingzhu said she was embarrassed, she even blushed. Liang Shi stared at her in astonishment, and after a moment, said gloomily, "Guess who I'm with?"

Because Xu Qingzhu had met Lu Jiayi's fiancée and had been captivated by her aura, she asked upon hearing this: "Who?"

Liang Shi turned the screen around. "Your company's spokesperson."

Yang Shuyan was looking at her phone. Hearing this, she turned her head and waved at the camera. Xu Qingzhu also called out, "Sister Yan."

"Mm-hmm." Yang Shuyan responded.

Xu Qingzhu's reaction wasn't even as big as when Lu Jiayi's fiancée was mentioned just now.

Liang Shi asked, "Do you kind of like her?"

"Who?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi's tone was aggrieved. "Lu Jiayi's fiancée."

"She has a name," Xu Qingzhu said. "It's Fu You—the 'You' as in 'enchanting beauty of the mortal world.'"¹

Her admiration was overflowing from the screen.

Liang Shi: ".....You really do like her a lot."

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Yes, you'd like her too if you met her."

"Liking you is enough for me," Liang Shi said. "I don't have such a big heart to like everyone."

"Not me though." Xu Qingzhu blinked at the screen. "I like lots of people—Sister Yan, Xixi, Dr. Zhao, Lu Jiayi—but I only love you."

Liang Shi: "....."

Somehow, she couldn't bring herself to be angry.

She let out a soft huff. "You sure like a lot of people."

"Of course." Xu Qingzhu lay down, showing her profile. "Everyone is so wonderful. What's wrong with liking them a little? Don't you like them too?"

Liang Shi's voice was muffled. "What I have is called appreciation."

"Really, if you met Fu You, you'd appreciate her too." Xu Qingzhu was still promoting her. "At dinner tonight, she wrapped roast duck for me and even winked at me. If I didn't know she was an Omega, I really would have been smitten."

Liang Shi: "....."

This was getting more and more outrageous.

"Whether she's an Omega or not has nothing to do with it—she's Lu Jiayi's fiancée," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head helplessly. "I don't know why, but Lu Jiayi and I really have similar tastes."

Liang Shi: "....."

Indeed.

You two are the ones who are a match made in heaven.

Liang Shi said helplessly, "You fickle person."

Xu Qingzhu laughed softly. "What? Jealous?"

Liang Shi pinched her ear and responded somewhat embarrassedly, "Mm."

Yang Shuyan, lying on the other bed, took out her earphones from nearby and put them on, then video-called Zhao Ying.

Zhao Ying, who was applying a face mask and planning to watch a drama, answered: "What?"

Her tone was perfunctory and casual.

"What are you doing?" Yang Shuyan asked.

Zhao Ying: "?"

"Didn't we just do it the day before yesterday?" Zhao Ying said. "I'm hurt. Can't do it anymore."

Yang Shuyan: ".....Is that all there is between us?"

Zhao Ying looked surprised. "What else? Miss Yang, you know me—I only crave your body."

Yang Shuyan: ".....Are you coming to visit the set?"

Zhao Ying was even more surprised. "Please, you're just recording a variety show. We don't have anything that needs joint marketing recently. It's better to keep our distance."

Yang Shuyan: "....."

Seeing that her expression wasn't great, Zhao Ying asked out of politeness, "What's wrong with you? What did you actually call me for?"

Yang Shuyan: ".....I just ate a mouthful of dog food."²

Zhao Ying's mind clicked and she immediately knew who it was. She laughed, "They're legally married, so what? You want that too? Isn't your dad making you go on blind dates?"

Yang Shuyan: "....."

"What would you do if I went on a blind date?" Yang Shuyan said. "Get married?"

Zhao Ying was stunned. "How could that be? I'll focus on my career. While you're getting married and having kids, I'll go film a few more dramas, surpass your achievements, and crush Yang Shuyan completely from then on."

Yang Shuyan: "?"

Yang Shuyan hung up in a huff. Zhao Ying sent her a message: [What? You hung up on me? Are you crazy?]

Yang Shuyan: [I missed you.]

Zhao Ying: [? You want me dead?]

Yang Shuyan: [I really do want to strangle you.]

Zhao Ying: [...Look at you, wanting to commit domestic violence against me.]

Yang Shuyan: [We're not even married. How is that domestic violence?]

Zhao Ying: [Then it's abusing a f*ck buddy?]

Yang Shuyan: [...How about we make it official?]

Zhao Ying: [?]

"Yang Shuyan recalled a message."

Footnotes:

¹ **"The 'You' as in 'enchanted beauty of the mortal world'" (人間尤物の尤):** The character 尤 (yóu) in the name Fu You (傅尤) is explained using the phrase "人間尤物" (rénjiān yóuwù), which means "an enchanting beauty of the mortal world" or "a femme fatale." It's a way of explaining how to write the character while also complimenting the person's beauty.

² **"Dog food" (狗粮):** Chinese internet slang for public displays of affection (PDA). Single people who witness couples being lovey-dovey are said to be "fed dog food" or "eating dog food," implying they're treated like dogs being fed scraps while watching others enjoy romance.